

Timeline of life

Earth's history stretches back 4.6 billion years to our planet's birth. Scientists divide this vast span of time into different periods, such as the Jurassic Period, when many of the dinosaurs lived. Here you can see all the periods on a timeline showing the history of life.

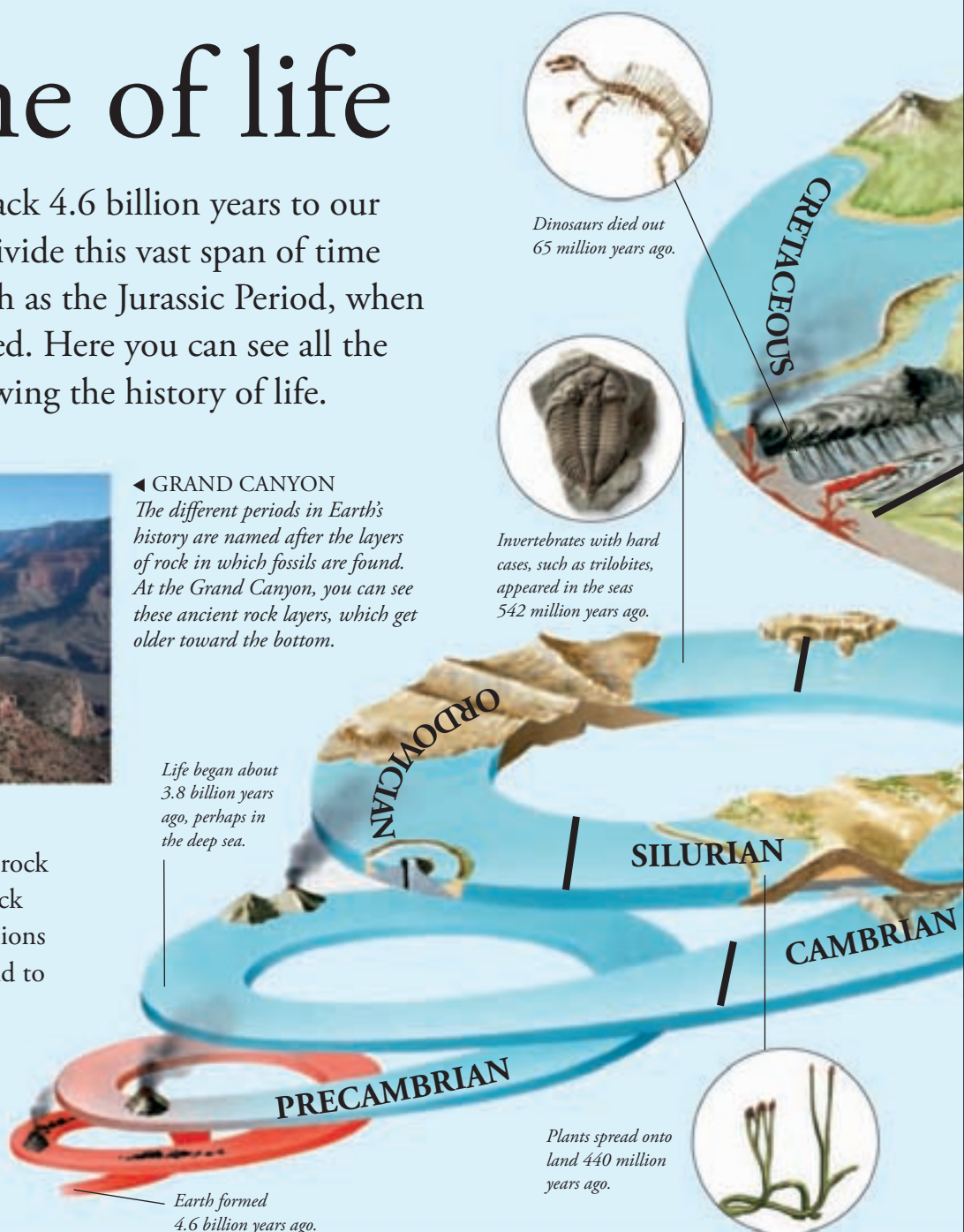


◀ **GRAND CANYON**
The different periods in Earth's history are named after the layers of rock in which fossils are found. At the Grand Canyon, you can see these ancient rock layers, which get older toward the bottom.

THE LINES TELL TALES

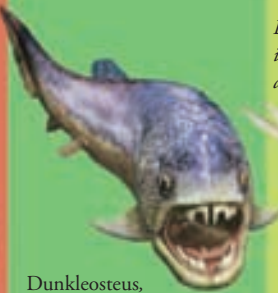
The past leaves clues buried in the rock below our feet. Certain types of rock build up in layers (strata) over millions of years. Different layers correspond to different periods in Earth's history.

► **EARTH'S HISTORY** is divided into very long stretches of time called eras. These are further divided into shorter stretches called periods, such as the Jurassic and Triassic.



ERAS AND PERIODS

PALEOZOIC ERA

PRECAMBRIAN	CAMBRIAN	ORDOVICIAN	SILURIAN	DEVONIAN	CARBONIFEROUS
4.6 billion to 542 million years ago	542–488 million years ago	488–444 million years ago	444–416 million years ago	416–358 million years ago	358–299 million years ago
	Trilobites scuttled around on the seafloor (see pages 36–37). 	Starfish (sea stars) became common in the sea (see pages 40–41). 	Pseudocrinites anchored itself to the seabed in the late Silurian. 	Dunkleosteus, a giant predator, terrorized the seas (see page 68). 	Dragonflies and other insects buzzed through the air (see pages 54–55). 